PROJECT SYNDICATE DIGEST

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1. The Politics of Poland’s Judicial Crisis

Author: Maciej Kisilowski **Published:** Nov 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WARSAW—Dramatic scenes are playing out at Poland’s Constitutional Tribunal amid a wave of speculation about whether Prime Minister Donald Tusk’s government and the Tribunal judges elected by its liberal parliamentary majority are acting lawfully. Many will ask whether democrats must break the law to restore institutions sabotaged by populist authoritarians. In the Polish case, it’s the wrong question.

2. A Tory Mentor for the MAGA GOP

Author: Michael R. Strain **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—“There is a fight coming in British politics. A fight that we have not seen in this country for more than half a century. It will be a battle for the soul of this nation. A battle of ideas. A battle that goes to the very core of who we are and what kind of country we want to be.”

3. If AI Thinks for Us, Democracy Will Suffer

Author: John Palfrey **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CHICAGO—Sometime in the 18th century, the Enlightenment settled a contentious, centuries-old question: Where does knowledge come from? For millennia, many people had pointed to God. But the early modern period brought a new consensus, namely that knowledge comes from human scientists working at the edge of what is known, armed with observation, mathematics, experimentation, and logic.

4. A Debtors’ Club for a Fragmented World

Author: Ishac Diwan **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BANGKOK—For seven decades, some of the world’s biggest official creditors have coordinated their positions in negotiations with debtor countries struggling with repayment. The Paris Club has sought not only to tackle debt treatment for individual sovereigns, but also to shape the rules governing bailouts and conditionality, largely by leveraging its 22 permanent members’ influence at the International Monetary Fund. Now, the world’s debtors have created a club of their own. The question is whether its stated goals are sufficiently ambitious.

5. Trump’s Tariff Fiasco Could Save Free Trade

Author: Anne O. Krueger **Published:** Nov 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—In the nearly two years since he returned to the White House, US President Donald Trump has picked up where he left off in his first term, shredding the open multilateral trading system that has served the world so well since the end of World War II. He has imposed sweeping tariffs on dozens of countries, repeatedly raising and lowering them and changing rates on individual goods and countries, seemingly on a whim. As a result, US tariff rates are now higher than at any time since the Great Depression’s Smoot-Hawley tariffs.

6. Europe’s Bright Future

Author: Thomas Buberl **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—I was born in Germany, I studied in Switzerland and the United Kingdom, and I served as a reserve officer in the French Navy. Today, I am a French citizen leading a French company that operates in more than 50 countries. I am, above all, a European.

7. Poland’s Constitutional Civil War

Author: Sławomir Sierakowski **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WARSAW—In a shocking moment that went viral, Polish President Karol Nawrocki and his cronies were recently filmed breaking into the Constitutional Tribunal in the dead of night and brutally shoving aside the judges they encountered, including an elderly woman. What or who were they coming for?

8. The Tech Brotherhood Wants Sovereignty

Author: Katharina Pistor **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Over several centuries, nation-states have come to define the international system and govern much of humanity. After emerging in modern Europe and spreading through colonialism, they eventually made it to every corner of the world through postwar decolonization. Their defining feature is control over territory and its inhabitants, without interference by others.

9. The Far Right’s Vision for Europe

Author: Mark Leonard **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—Recent events have cast European politics into sharper relief. With left-wing protests, some violent, engulfing cities from Paris to Milan to Madrid, the right has remained focused on big upcoming elections, and most mainstream parties appeared to be in retreat. It may be too soon to guess at the outcomes in Spain, France, Poland, and Italy, but there can be little doubt that far-right and populist ideas will shape the Europe that emerges from these contests. That much is clear to me after spending the past few months talking to leading “new right” politicians and strategists in France, Poland, Germany, and Italy.

10. Oligarchic World Order

Author: David Lingelbach **Published:** Nov 3, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BALTIMORE/BOGOTÁ—For most people, the word “oligarch” conjures images of Russian elites who amassed huge fortunes in the wake of the Soviet Union’s collapse or, more recently, the tech billionaires who filled the front row at US President Donald Trump’s second inauguration. But oligarchs are global, systemic, and increasingly entrenched. They are a defining feature of the emerging world order.

11. The Rise and Fall of Privacy

Author: Tiffany Jenkins **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—In the 17th century, a common injunction held that you should “do nothing privately that you would not do publicly. Task yourself, lest privacy becomes your enemy.” Going further, one preacher even warned that privacy was for “adulterers and murderers.” The devil comes to you when you are on your own. You should find it reassuring to be watched.

12. The ECB Must Bail Out France

Author: Desmond Lachman **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—The grandiose claim that “Britannia rules the waves” inspired the wry quip that, in fact, Britannia waives the rules. While the pun was meant as a putdown, waiving rules can be a prudent decision. That is certainly the case for the European Central Bank today, as it weighs its options for helping France, Europe’s second-largest economy, cope with its $4 trillion debt.

13. Dot-Com Lessons for the AI Bubble

Author: Chi Onwurah **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—It is a truth universally acknowledged that transformative new technologies rewrite the rules of finance. Or so we are told in numerous commentaries, social-media posts, and regulatory filings relating to the current AI investment boom, which may well prove to be a bubble.

14. A Fatal Challenge to Mainstream Economics

Author: James K. Galbraith **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

KASHGAR—In what is best read as a preemptive swipe at Isabella Weber's new book, Anti-Fascist Economics, Jason Furman, the chair of the White House Council of Economic Advisers during US President Barack Obama's second term, recently offered the following half-truth: "the fatal challenge to heterodox economics is that there isn't actually orthodox economics."

15. China Is Defanging the Dollar, Not Dethroning It

Author: Ho-fung Hung **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—After Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, the United States sought to freeze Russia out of the global financial system, leading many to speculate that weaponization of the US dollar's dominance of that system would accelerate the world's shift away from the greenback. Speculation only intensified when the US launched its war against Iran earlier this year and tightened its financial sanctions on the country.

16. Good Institutions Require Good People

Author: Deirdre Nansen McCloskey **Published:** Nov 4, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—We should have learned by now that good politics depends not so much on good institutions as on the moral sentiments supporting them. If bad or unwise people take over your country by coup or by vote, you can’t rely on your institutions to save you. “Add institutions and stir” has never been a consistent recipe for success; good and wise people are.